VIT Bhopal University

VITyarthi E-Learning Platform

CSE0001 – Digital Literacy

Project Report – Digital Literacy Portfolio

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Introduction

This project report has been prepared as part of the CSE0001 – Digital Literacy course at VIT Bhopal University, under the VITyarthi E-Learning Platform. The assignment is structured around the scenario of a Student Digital Ambassador, a role that demands both technical competence and the ability to communicate digital best practices effectively to peers. As a student pursuing B.Tech in Computer Science with a specialisation in Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning, this project offers a meaningful opportunity to establish the foundational digital skills that will underpin every stage of my academic and professional journey.

The project is divided into five tasks, each corresponding to a core module of the course. These tasks collectively address the full spectrum of digital literacy, ranging from visual communication and professional online presence, to coding platform familiarity, professional email etiquette, and cybercrime awareness. The deliverable is a structured GitHub repository containing all task artefacts, supplemented by this written report. The tasks have been approached not merely as academic exercises but as genuine real-world competencies. Each section of this report provides an analytical and descriptive account of the work undertaken, the tools employed, the challenges encountered, and the reflections gained. The underlying objective is to document not just what was done, but why it matters in the context of becoming a responsible, capable, and informed digital citizen.

Task 1 – Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

Overview

Task 1 required the creation of a one-page visual resource aimed at helping batchmates understand the concept of Digital Literacy and its practical significance. The target audience comprised first-year engineering students who may have varying levels of familiarity with digital tools and responsible online practices. Communicating complex, multi-faceted concepts in a single visual demanded careful thought about both design and content prioritisation.

Tool Used: Canva

The chosen design platform for this task was Canva (canva.com). Canva is a cloud-based graphic design tool that provides an intuitive drag-and-drop interface, a rich library of templates, icons, fonts, and colour palettes — all without requiring any graphic design expertise. Its browser-based nature aligns with the requirement for free, accessible tooling, and its collaborative features make it particularly suitable for academic use.

Canva was selected over alternatives such as Piktochart or Prezi because of its superior template ecosystem for infographic design and its ease of exporting high-resolution images. The platform's layout grids and alignment guides enabled a clean, professional visual aesthetic that would otherwise require hours of manual positioning in a tool like PowerPoint.

Design and Content

For my project, I used a digital design tool called Canva to create an infographic about digital citizenship and literacy. The design presents key ideas such as what digital literacy means, useful tools for students, and safe internet practices. I organized the information into clear sections with headings, icons, and short explanations so that it is easy to read and visually engaging. The infographic highlights skills like information searching, critical thinking, media literacy, and basic technical skills. It also includes tips for using digital tools for research, organization, creation, and collaboration, along with advice on staying safe online, such as using strong passwords and avoiding suspicious links.
One thing I found interesting while making this project was how important layout and color choices are in making information understandable. It was challenging at first to fit all the information without making the design look crowded, but adjusting spacing

and simplifying text helped improve clarity. Overall, the process helped me better understand both digital literacy and effective visual communication.

Reflection

The most intellectually interesting aspect of this task was the challenge of information hierarchy — deciding what to include and, more critically, what to leave out. An infographic that attempts to say everything ends up communicating nothing effectively. Distilling the concept of digital literacy to its most actionable core required genuine understanding of the subject matter rather than surface-level summarisation.

The most practically challenging aspect was achieving visual balance. Canva's template system accelerated the initial layout, but customising colours, font sizes, and icon placements to create a cohesive and visually compelling output required multiple iterations. This exercise fundamentally changed how I think about visual communication — good design is not decoration; it is the architecture of comprehension.

Task 2 – Student Digital Portfolio

Overview

Task 2 focused on establishing a professional digital presence across multiple platforms. In an era where academic and professional opportunities are increasingly discovered and evaluated online, having well-maintained profiles on the right platforms is no longer optional — it is a fundamental component of career readiness. This task required the creation or update of accounts on at least three platforms from a prescribed list, each serving a distinct professional function.

Platforms Selected

The three platforms selected were GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle. Each was chosen on the basis of its direct relevance to a student pursuing AI and Machine Learning.

GitHub

GitHub (github.com) is the world's most widely used platform for version control and collaborative software development. Built on the Git distributed version control system, GitHub enables developers to host code repositories, track changes, collaborate with teams, and showcase their projects publicly. For a student in AI/ML, GitHub is the primary portfolio platform — analogous to a portfolio website for a designer or a publication list for a researcher.

A profile README was created by establishing a special repository named after my username. This README includes my full name, registration number, branch and year of study, and a brief statement of intent: what I hope to learn and build over the course of my degree. The README was written in Markdown, providing an opportunity to learn this lightweight markup language that is ubiquitous in technical documentation, data science notebooks, and open-source projects.

LinkedIn

LinkedIn (linkedin.com) is the world's leading professional networking platform, with over one billion members globally. It functions as a living, updatable resume that is accessible to recruiters, hiring managers, professors, and collaborators. The

Education section was completed with current degree information (B.Tech – CSE AI&ML), institution name (VIT Bhopal University), and expected graduation year. LinkedIn will serve as the primary platform for internship applications, research connections, and professional networking throughout my academic career.

Kaggle

Kaggle (kaggle.com) is the world's largest data science and machine learning community, owned by Google. It hosts publicly accessible datasets, machine learning competitions, free online courses, and community notebooks. For a student in AI/ML, Kaggle occupies a unique position as both a learning platform and a competitive arena. Completing Kaggle courses and earning medals in competitions is widely recognised by data science recruiters as evidence of genuine practical skill beyond classroom learning.

Reflection

Setting up these three profiles provided a compelling exercise in professional self-presentation. The experience of writing the GitHub README — describing my goals to an invisible but very real audience of potential collaborators and employers — brought an unexpected degree of intentionality to thinking about what I actually want to achieve over the next four years. The exercise reframed these platforms not as sign-up forms to be completed, but as ongoing professional commitments.

Over the coming four years, GitHub will serve as the repository of my actual work, LinkedIn will document my milestones and connections, and Kaggle will provide structured pathways into real data science challenges. Together, these three platforms constitute a coherent, interconnected professional identity that will evolve alongside my skills.

Task 3 – Coding and Collaboration Platforms

Overview

Task 3 required engagement with two distinct categories of digital tool: a competitive programming and skill assessment platform (Part A), and a cloud-based collaboration tool in the form of Google Workspace (Part B). The underlying objective was to build familiarity with the tools that are most commonly used for technical skill development and academic collaboration at the undergraduate level.

Reflection

For Task 3, I used **HackerRank** to practice coding skills. I completed a beginner-level challenge, which helped me understand problem-solving logic and basic programming concepts. The platform provides structured problems that are useful for improving coding ability gradually.
Additionally, I created a Google Form as a Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz. The form included five questions, such as multiple-choice and short-answer types, to test students' understanding of digital literacy concepts. I also viewed responses through Google Sheets, which helped me understand how data is collected and analyzed.
This task was very useful because it introduced me to both coding practice and collaborative tools. HackerRank helps in building programming skills, while Google Forms is useful for surveys, quizzes, and data collection.
These tools will be beneficial academically as they improve both technical and analytical skills, which are essential for my field in AI and Machine Learning

Task 4 – Professional Email Etiquette

Overview

Task 4 addressed one of the most practically undervalued yet consequential aspects of professional digital life: written communication. The ability to compose a clear, courteous, and appropriately structured email is a core professional competency that transcends industry and role. This task required writing two professional emails and creating a social media etiquette checklist.

Social Media Do's and Don'ts Checklist

☑ DO	✕ DON'T
Keep your privacy settings updated on all platforms	Post your home address, phone number, or daily schedule publicly
Think before you post — assume anything you share is permanent	Share unverified news or forward viral messages without fact-checking
Report harassment, hate speech, and misinformation using platform tools	Engage in or ignore cyberbullying directed at others
Use your real identity on professional platforms (LinkedIn, GitHub)	Create fake profiles or impersonate others online
Log out of accounts on shared or public devices	Save passwords on college lab computers or public devices

Reflection: A Case of Poor Digital Communication

A widely documented real-world example of poor digital communication resulting in severe professional consequences is the 2013 case of Justine Sacco, a public relations executive who posted an ill-considered tweet before boarding a long-haul flight. The tweet, intended as dark humour, was deeply offensive in nature. By the time her flight landed, the tweet had gone globally viral, her employer had publicly distanced itself from her, and she had lost her job. What made this case particularly instructive is that Sacco had fewer than 200 followers at the time of posting — the tweet spread entirely through retweet and engagement, demonstrating that the 'small' size of one's audience offers no protection against viral amplification. The fundamental error was the assumption of an informal, private context in a medium that is inherently public and permanent. Had Sacco paused before posting — asking the simple question, "Would I say this in a formal meeting?" — the consequences could have been entirely

avoided. The lesson for college students is unambiguous: professional and social media accounts are not separate selves. They are a single, unified digital identity.

Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness: Case Study & Prevention Guide

Overview

Task 5 required research into a real or realistic cybercrime scenario and the production of two deliverables: a detailed case study and a practical prevention checklist. The cybercrime type selected for this task is UPI and Online Payment Fraud, chosen because of its immediate and growing relevance to the Indian student population. With the rapid expansion of the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) ecosystem across India — which processed over 18 billion transactions in a single month in 2024 — payment fraud has emerged as one of the most prevalent forms of cybercrime affecting young adults in the country.

Stay Safe Online: Prevention Checklist for College Students

#	Prevention Tip
1	Never enter your UPI PIN to receive money. A PIN is only required when you are sending money. If someone asks you to 'enter PIN to receive', it is a fraud. [UPI SAFETY]
2	Verify the identity of anyone requesting a UPI payment by calling them on a known, verified number before transferring any amount. [UPI SAFETY]
3	Use strong, unique passwords for all accounts. A strong password contains uppercase and lowercase letters, numbers, and special characters, and is at least 12 characters long.
4	Enable two-factor authentication (2FA) on email, social media, and banking apps. This adds a critical second layer of protection even if your password is compromised.
5	Do not click links in unsolicited SMS or WhatsApp messages claiming to be from banks, government bodies, or scholarship portals. Always access official sites by typing the URL directly.
6	Avoid using public Wi-Fi for any financial transactions or logging into sensitive accounts. If unavoidable, use a trusted VPN service.
7	Regularly review your bank and UPI transaction history. Set up instant SMS and app notification alerts for every transaction so that any unauthorised activity is detected immediately.
8	If you suspect fraud, act within the first hour. Call your bank's helpline to freeze the account if necessary, and immediately report the incident to the National Cyber Crime Portal at cybercrime.gov.in or dial Helpline 1930 (available 24x7).

> ⚠ **Report Cybercrime:** National Cyber Crime Portal — cybercrime.gov.in | Helpline: 1930 (24x7)

Reflection

The aspect of this research that proved most surprising was not the sophistication of the fraud techniques themselves — many of which rely on elementary social engineering rather than technical exploits — but rather the scale and speed at which these crimes operate. UPI fraud is not carried out by lone actors; it is industrialised. Documented investigations by Indian law enforcement have uncovered organised networks operating from specific geographic hubs, running fraud as a structured business with scripts, shift systems, and performance targets. The criminals involved are often young people themselves, recruited into fraud networks with promises of easy income.

A second surprising finding was the reporting gap: a large proportion of UPI fraud victims never file a formal complaint, primarily due to shame or the belief that the lost amount is too small to pursue. This silence is precisely what allows fraudsters to operate with impunity. Reporting every incident, regardless of the amount, contributes to the data that law enforcement uses to identify patterns and dismantle networks.

As a direct result of this research, I will make one specific and immediate behavioural change: I will never approve a UPI transaction without first verifying the nature of the request (send or receive) and the identity of the counterparty through an independent communication channel. The few seconds this takes are a negligible cost against the consequences of falling victim to a fraud that is, in hindsight, entirely preventable.

Conclusion

This project has been a comprehensive and genuinely formative exercise in digital literacy. Across five tasks, it moved from the conceptual to the practical, from the creative to the analytical, and from the individual to the societal. The infographic task sharpened visual communication skills; the portfolio task established a permanent professional digital identity; the platforms task built familiarity with the tools of technical practice and academic collaboration; the email etiquette task developed the professional communication skills that every career depends upon; and the cybercrime task cultivated the awareness and habits necessary to navigate an increasingly complex digital threat landscape.

The overarching insight from this project is that digital literacy is not a static body of knowledge but a dynamic practice. The tools change, the threats evolve, and the platforms that matter today may be superseded tomorrow. What endures is the underlying disposition: curiosity tempered by critical thinking, confidence grounded in competence, and an understanding that every digital action carries consequences — for oneself and for others. The GitHub repository built through this project is not merely a submission artefact. It is the first page of a professional story that will be written, revised, and expanded over the next four years and beyond.

References

The following tools, platforms, and resources were consulted or used in the completion of this project:

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